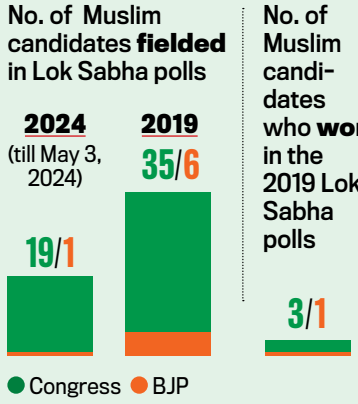
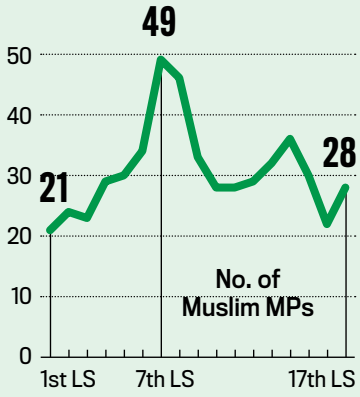
DO MUSLIMS TILT

HOW THE COMMUNITY VOTES, HOW THE PARTIES FIELD THEM AND HOW MANY GET ELECTED TO THE LOK SABHA

MUSLIM CANDIDATES FIELDED BY THE BJP AND THE CONGRESS

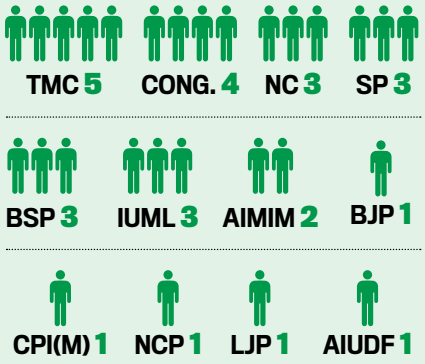


MUSLIM REPRESENTATION IN THE LOK SABHA



PARTY-WISE DISTRIBUTION

No. of Muslim MPs in 2019



WHERE ARE THE MUSLIM MPs?

The five states with the highest Muslim population account for 224 MPs in the Lok Sabha. Only 18 were Muslim in the 17th Lok Sabha

STATE	TOTAL MUSLIM POPULATION	SHARE OF TOTAL POPULATION	TOTAL LOK SABHA SEATS	MUSLIM MPs 2019
Uttar Pradesh	38 mn	19%	80	6
West Bengal	25 mn	27%	42	7
Bihar	18 mn	17%	40	2
Maharashtra	13 mn	12%	48	1
Assam	11 mn	34%	14	2

Sources: Election Commission of India, Census 2011, Lokniti-CSDS

Muslim-Yadav vote bank. The grand alliance hopes that unified voting by the Muslims will help them snatch all the eight seats in Bihar that have a Muslim population of at least 20 per cent. The NDA occupies seven of them currently.

In Maharashtra, the political twists and turns have led to the emergence of a surprise champion for Muslim votes. The community is now looking at the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray)—legatee of the original flagbearer of Hindu supremacy—as its best bet this time. It's a tactical choice, as among all the constituents of the MVA, the Sena (UBT) faction has the possibility of attracting the highest Hindu votes in a direct contest with the BJP. The Muslim addition to that can only tilt the total vote share in favour of the Sena (UBT), which is also contesting in 21 of the state's 48 seats, the highest among the three MVA partners. Besides, in both the seats where the Muslim population is over 20 per cent—Mumbai South and Aurangabad—the Sena (UBT) represents the MVA.

However, there's a flip side to the consolidation of the Muslim vote against the BJP, even if it benefits the Opposition parties. A study by Congress data cell head Praveen Chakravarty shows that the BJP's vote share actually increases in districts that have significantly more (1.5x or more) Muslims than the average in that state. As BJP leader Atif Rasheed, president of the Rashtrawadi Muslim Pasmanda Mahaz, explains, the fear-mongering by the non-BJP parties among Muslim voters consolidates the Hindus against them. "Muslims should not be under the illusion that they can make and break governments. They should rather focus on who has delivered them governance," he says.

Even the Congress Nyay Patra, which the BJP has labelled the "Muslim League manifesto", actually refrains from mentioning the word Muslim even once. "After what has happened in the past 10 years, the Muslims are not going to vote for the BJP," says a senior Congress Rajya Sabha member. "Their options are limited to the non-BJP parties. By making any direct appeal, we are likely to fall into the BJP's trap and unnecessarily create wrong perceptions among the Hindu voters." The Congress, in fact, has reduced the number of its Muslim candidates from 35 in 2019 to 19 this time, partly because it is fighting only 330 seats as compared to 421 seats.